# 5
# The One with the Legs

*‘I’m in Manchester but I’ll drive down. We could go out.’*

My wife picked me out of a soccer sticker book. And I chose her off the telly.

Considering I grew up in Chingford and Victoria lived in Goff’s Oak—fifteen minutes’ drive away—it seems we traveled a very long way round before finding one another. We’d been to the same shops, eaten in the same restaurants, danced in the same clubs but never actually come face to face during twenty-odd North-east London years. Once we finally met, we had all that catching up to do. It felt straight away like we’d always been meant to be together. Maybe everything that had gone before was just about us getting ready for the real thing to happen.

It’s November 1996. I’m sitting in a hotel bedroom in Tbilisi, the night before a World Cup qualifier against Georgia. Gary Neville, my room-mate, is lying on the other bed in the room. Aside from the matches themselves, overseas trips, whether it’s with my club or with England, aren’t my favorite part of being a professional player. What do you see? What do you do? Eat, sleep and train; sit in rooms that all look the same as the last one. That particular hotel in Georgia, the only one up to international standards after the break-up of the old Soviet Union, was built in a square, with balconies piled up on each side overlooking an open area containing the lobby, bars and restaurant. All the bedroom doors faced across at each other, there was steel and glass everywhere. This place felt even more like a prison than most. Looking out of the window, I could see a half-built dual carriageway and a grey river oozing along beside it. It wasn’t the kind of view that made you think about going out for an evening stroll.

So Gary and I are just chatting. The television’s on in the corner, tuned to